

The Noble Great Staff Dhāraṇī

Āryamahādaṇḍanāmadhāraṇī · Toh 606 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་བཅོམ་ཆེན་པོ་ཞེས་བརྒྱུད་གྲུག་

Toh 606 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in English as "The Noble Great Staff," in Sanskrit as the Āryamahādaṇḍanāmadhāraṇī, and in Tibetan as Phags pa be con chen po zhes bya ba'i gzungs. As a dhāraṇī sūtra, it belongs to the broader class of protective and ritual literature within the Buddhist canon, presenting a sacred formula endowed with apotropaic power. The text opens with a scene set on Vulture Peak Mountain at Rājagṛha, where the Buddha resides with a great assembly of monks, while the Venerable Rāhula finds himself in a charnel ground called the Cool Grove, surrounded by a vast array of spirits and supernatural beings. This setting establishes the context for the dhāraṇī's protective function, suggesting it was transmitted to guard against the many threatening forces enumerated at the text's opening.

In the language of India: Āryamahādaṇḍanāmadhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Great Staff."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain at Rājagṛha, together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks. At that time the Venerable Rāhula was in a direction like that of a great funeral pyre in the great charnel ground called the Cool Grove at Rājagṛha. There, spirits of gods, spirits of asuras, spirits of nāgas, spirits of yakṣas, spirits of rākṣasas, spirits of kiṃnaras, spirits of great serpents, spirits of gandharvas, spirits of humans, spirits of wind-gods, spirits of hungry ghosts, spirits of bhūtas, spirits of flesh-eaters, spirits of kumbhāṇḍas, leopards, crows, owls, scorpions, venomous snakes, and moreover humans and non-human sentient beings were causing the Venerable Rāhula great harm.

Then the Venerable Rāhula went toward Vulture Peak Mountain, toward where the Blessed One was, and having arrived, he bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and wept in the presence of the Blessed One, his tears streaming down.

Then the Blessed One said to the Venerable Rāhula: "Rāhula, why do you sit before me weeping?" When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the Venerable Rāhula said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, when I was in the direction like that of a great funeral pyre in the great charnel ground called the Cool Grove at Rājagṛha, spirits of gods, spirits of asuras, spirits of nāgas, spirits of yakṣas, spirits of rākṣasas, spirits of kiṃnaras, spirits of gandharvas, spirits of great serpents, spirits of humans, spirits of wind-gods, spirits of hungry ghosts, spirits of bhūtas, spirits of flesh-eaters, spirits of kumbhāṇḍas, leopards, crows, owls, scorpions, venomous snakes, and moreover humans and non-human sentient beings were causing me great harm."

Then the Blessed One said to the Venerable Rāhula: "Rāhula, receive and hold this dhāraṇī vidyā-mantra of the four circuits of the Great Staff, so that it may protect, guard, and shelter monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, and be for their long-term benefit, wellbeing, and happiness.

Thus:

Oṃ gā, baṃ gā, taṃ gā, taraṃ gā, taraṃ gā, sarā sarā, taraṃ gāsva, sadad sa, jadhārā, akkare, arabīrā, tarabīrā, karabīrā, karkarabīrā, curubīrā, curucurubīrā, indra, indrakī, sarahanasa, hanasaki sara, mecireḷā, mahāmicchavahiṣīkā, kaliccaka, aṃgejaye, jayelikā, elā, cinta, lile, tiletile, sumati, pumati, culunatte, culuculu natte, culanate, kunati, harītaki, narītakita, gaurī, gandhārī, dhāraṇī, dhāraṇe, uṣṭa, pipīlikā, uṣṭa, papīlake, karākarjike."

kākele, calanāṭṭi, kāgimāli, lāmatirakṣamati, bālakuli, batasale, unmile, tarābīre, taratarābīre, kurubīre, kurukurubīre, curucuru, curucuru, curucurubīre, mahābīre, iramati, barmati, rakṣamati, sarvārthasādhani, paramasura sādhani, apratihaṭe.

King Indra (the king who is Lord of the Gods), King of the Moon, King Yama (the Lord of Death), King of the Wind Gods, the Resplendent King, the son of the King Vaiśravaṇa (lord of wealth), King Vecon, King Without-Vecon, King Brahmā of the Thousand, and the Buddha, the Blessed One, Lord of the Dharma, King of the Dharma — you who have unsurpassed love and compassion for all the world, I implore you to protect me, to fully shelter, fully guard, and fully sustain me; to bring peace and wellbeing; to ward off punishment and weapons; to destroy poison and neutralize poison; to cut through obstacles and bind the ground.

Thus: ilamile, tasalā, iramati, biramati, calamati, phurumatī, phuruphurū, phuruphurū, parakhururu, khurumati, bhūmimaṇḍe, kalike, caṇḍali, akisarāli, ayāsā, salamato, hale, sṭhule, śalejaya, sṭhule, calanāṭi, calanāṭi,

nāgandhāraṇī, gorahinī, goletihe, aṇḍare, paṇḍare, keyūre, kitumati, bhūtaṃgame, bhūtabate, dhārye, mahābale, acuṇḍe, acurunde, dharandharā, jayalikā, jalegorohani, cara, huruhuru, rumdhurumdhū, huru, dhumati, dharandharedhare, viśvamati, nāśani, bandhanī, mocani, vimocani, sādhani, śodhani, viśodhani, saṃgiranī, maṃthīranī, acchidatani, pādhuṭaramale, tarataramaṇī, harahara, bandhūmati, hirihi, giligile, huruhuru, biṃgalesvāhā.

Homage to the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones.

This dhāraṇī of the great planet-seizing comet, the mantra compendium of one hundred and ten, when knotted onto a cord and tied to the hand or hung about the neck, will, throughout a circle of ten leagues in every direction, cause one to be protected by vajras, flowers, and mudrās. Neither humans nor non-humans will be able to cause harm. Weapons, poison, sickness, contagious disease, virulent plague, vidyā mantras and secret mantras, reanimated corpses, fierce and wrathful forces, and death by fire or by water — none of these will bring one's end at that time. As for all the applications of vidyā mantras and secret mantras: all those applications that are well applied will bring to fruition those that have not yet succeeded. Those that have already succeeded will not be caused to decay. The workings of adversaries will be bound. Those bound by adversaries will be freed. Sickness, sorrow, and obstructions will be utterly destroyed. The turmoil of strife will be thoroughly pacified. All possessing spirits will be repelled. Whatever possessing spirit sends harm, its head will be split into seven pieces like the seed pod of an arjaka plant. The great commander of yakṣas, Vajrapāṇi — who is himself a vajra blazing, blazing everywhere, blazing everywhere with full intensity, having become a single mass of flame — will likewise split that spirit's head into seven pieces like the seed pod of an arjaka plant. The Four Great Kings will also shatter it with weapons of iron wheels with razor-sharp edges. After dying from that yakṣa world, the spirit will not find a place to dwell in the retinue of the Palace of the Graceful Willows. The planet-seizing king, wild men, fire, water, weapons, wild animals, solitary places, mountains,

As for someone who has gone into the wilderness: if they recite this awareness mantra of the Great Spear dhāraṇī even once, they will be completely liberated from all evil.

This awareness mantra of the Great Spear dhāraṇī — the dhāraṇī of the planet-seizing Great Spear — was spoken, is spoken, and will be spoken by as many buddhas, Blessed Ones, as there are grains of sand along ninety-one

rivers like the Ganges. It is supremely accomplished, irresistible to others, and praised by gods, nāgas, gandharvas, and the like; it is fully upheld by all spirits. May I and all sentient beings be made happy and free from every harm. May we be without sickness and without fear.

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One declared it, and the venerable Rāhu rejoiced and offered his praise for what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble dhāraṇī called the Great Spear is complete.

This was translated, revised, and definitively edited in the new orthographic style by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, together with the great editor-translator, the monk Ye shes sde.

Translator's Notes

- The title of this dhāraṇī in Sanskrit, Āryamahādaṇḍanāmadhāraṇī, means "The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Great Staff." The Tibetan rendering "be con chen po" (great staff or great cudgel) faithfully reflects "mahādaṇḍa."

The figure named in Tibetan as "sgra gcan 'dzin" (literally "the one who holds the seizer of sound," an epithet of Rāhula) is here rendered as "Rāhula," the well-known son and disciple of the Buddha. This is a standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit name Rāhula.

The phrase "four circuits" (Tibetan: 'khor bzhi pa) in the context of the mantra likely refers to four groups or rounds of the vidyā-mantra. The precise structural meaning of this term within the ritual context is not entirely transparent from the text alone.

The mantra syllables are transliterated as closely as possible from the Tibetan phonetic rendering of Sanskrit; standard critical editions may show variants.

- The names rendered as "King Vecon" and "King Without-Vecon" translate Tibetan རྒྱལ་པོ་ལེ་ཁོན་ and རྒྱལ་པོ་ལེ་ཁོན་མེད་, which appear to be transliterations of Sanskrit divine names not yet identified with certainty in the surviving parallel texts; they are rendered phonetically here rather than guessed at.

The "Palace of the Graceful Willows" renders འཆ་ལྷ་ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་ཡུལ་, which is Alakāvātī, the paradise-realm of Kubera and the yakṣas; the Tibetan is a semantic rendering of the Sanskrit name.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as the source text is cut off, and the translation preserves this.

- The colophon names three figures well attested in the early imperial Tibetan translation projects: Jinamitra and Dānaśīla are Sanskrit-side paṇḍitas, and Ye shes sde is the chief Tibetan lotsāwa and editor. The phrase rendered "new orthographic style" refers to the 9th-century linguistic standardization of Tibetan canonical translation terminology, the so-called skad gсар bcad reform. The title "Rāhu" for the venerable one in the assembly follows the identification of Rāhu as the planet-seizing deity established throughout this text.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.